1919–1943

DORIS "DORIE" MILLER

COOK THIRD CLASS, USS WEST VIRGINIA



Like most black sailors in the US Navy in 1941, Doris Miller was a mess attendant. When the Japanese struck Pearl Harbor he was on board the battleship *West Virginia*. Amid the inferno of the burning ship, Miller first attempted to save his wounded captain and then manned an anti-aircraft gun. He is credited with shooting down at least one Japanese aircraft, despite having no training. Miller was awarded the Navy Cross for "distinguished devotion to duty, extraordinary courage, and disregard for his own personal safety." He died in 1943 when the ship on which he was serving was sunk by a Japanese submarine.

an even worse fate: an armor-piercing bomb penetrated its forward magazine, setting off an explosion that ripped the battleship in two, killing more than a thousand of its crew.

A second wave of 170 aircraft arrived later in the morning to add to the mayhem. By the time it was all over, 18 American ships were sunk or disabled, including all the battleships. There were a few glimmers of light in an otherwise grim scene. The attempted attack by Japanese midget submarines was a total failure. The Japanese also failed to destroy the oil tanks at the base. And most important of all, the US Navy's four aircraft carriers were absent when the raid took place. But for the time being, the Japanese navy had established dominance in the Pacific.



USS Nevada on fire
Despite being damaged in the first wave of attacks, *Nevada* was the only battleship to get underway during the raid. The battleship was struck again and beached during the second wave of attacks.

WORLD WAR II

SINKING OF PRINCE OF WALES AND REPULSE



Date December 10, 1941
Forces British: 1 battleship, 1 battlecruiser, 4 destroyers; Japanese: 84 aircraft
Losses British: 1 battleship, 1 battlecruiser; Japanese: 6 aircraft
Location South China Sea

On December 2, 1941, the battleship *Prince of Wales* and the battlecruiser *Repulse* arrived at the British base at Singapore, along with four destroyers. They had been sent in the vain hope of deterring the Japanese from going to war. The ships should have been accompanied by a carrier, but a mishap en route left this under repair in the US.

On the same day as Pearl Harbor, the Japanese began landing troops in Malaya. Admiral Sir Tom Phillips sailed north from Singapore to intercept the landings. His ships, designated Force Z, were spotted by Japanese submarines and cruiser-carried reconnaissance aircraft. Aware that he had lost the advantage of surprise, Phillips turned back on the night of December 9–10.

Japanese naval aircraft of the 22nd Air Flotilla, based at airfields around Saigon in Japanese-occupied Indochina, failed to find Force Z that night, but the following morning they located the ships off Kuantan. Force Z was not unprepared for air defense—*Prince of Wales* alone mounted 175 anti-aircraft guns—but waves of attacks by conventional bombers and, in particular, torpedo-bombers were devastatingly effective. The air attacks began shortly after 11:00 a.m; *Repulse* sank at 12:30 p.m. and *Prince of Wales* at 1:20 p.m. Some 2,000 men were rescued by the destroyers, although Admiral Phillips was among those lost. This disaster left the Japanese in command of the seas and Malaya and Singapore exposed to Japanese conquest.



Air raid on Tokyo
A US Army Air Force B-25 takes off from the deck of the USS *Hornet* on its way to take part in the first US air raid on Japan – an important propaganda coup for the United States military.

WORLD WAR II

DOOLITTLE RAID



Date April 18, 1942
Forces Americans: 2 carriers, 4 cruisers, 8 destroyers, 16 aircraft
Losses Americans: 16 aircraft; Japanese c.50 civilians
Location Pacific Ocean and Tokyo, Japan

With Americans in desperate need of a morale boost, a plan was devised for a carrier raid on the Japanese homeland. The US Navy believed it could advance a carrier task force to within 400 miles (650 km) of Tokyo. As no naval airplane had sufficient range, the US Army Air Force agreed to supply B-25 Mitchell bombers, although no B-25 had ever flown from a flight deck. Lieutenant Colonel James Doolittle led the air side of the mission.

The carrier *Hornet* set to sea on April 2, 1942 with 16 B-25s tethered on the flight deck—they were too large to be stowed below. North of Hawaii *Hornet* rendezvoused with the carrier *Enterprise* and its escort of cruisers and destroyers. Maintaining strict radio silence, they had advanced to 650 miles (1,000 km) from Tokyo when, on the morning of April 18, they were spotted by a Japanese patrol boat. The decision was taken to launch the planes immediately, though the extra distance meant they would be unlikely to reach the airfield in a friendly area of China where they planned to land.

Doolittle had exhaustively practised short take-offs with his volunteer crews, but no one actually knew if the aircraft, laden with fuel and bombs, would launch from a pitching deck in a heavy sea. Remarkably, they took off without mishap and, four hours later, bombed Tokyo and other cities. All the aircraft were subsequently lost but most of the crews found their way back to the US. The raid was a severe embarrassment to Japanese military leaders and partly motivated their fateful decision to attack Midway the following June.